The Ashram began to expand to other Indian states from 1978 onwards. Speaking on the phone from Ranchi in September 2020, Atul Jog told me that the decision to expand beyond Madhya Pradesh was taken during a discussion between Deshpande and RSS Sarsanghchalak Balasaheb Deoras.[54] The foundations of its growth, interestingly, were laid in a seminar at the Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Mumbai, where the Ashram's state and national officer-bearers were trained in 1975. ABVKA leaders found the seven-day training of such 'special use' that, in 1976, they set up their own national training centre in Dadar and Nagar Haveli's Motra Randha village. It operated for many years, with several officials moving there to develop the training centre.[55] ABVKA's objective in expanding nationwide was to directly reach the 8.2 per cent of Indians who identify as tribals.[56]

To do this, it adopted the methods of modern NGO management and emulated the social-welfare work done by church bodies on education, medicine and financial support. In the 1980–2000 period, new ABVKA branches were registered as separate entities in each state. 'The country is so big,' says Jog. 'Languages are so different in each state. You can't run it centrally.'[57] By 1992, it had 563 full-time employees working in 119 districts with large tribal populations. ABVKA further estimated that its workers were in touch with over one-sixth of the country's villages (11,000 of 60,893 villages) at the time. K. Bhaskaran, ABVKA's then all-India organising secretary, explained that, in order to reach all 450 tribal groups in the country, his organisation focused on building primary and secondary schools, libraries, primary health centres and hospitals. 'The workers had also built temples for tribals in its efforts to spread the message of Hindutva in the country.' Outside of tribal communities in Hindi-speaking states, the Northeast emerged as a new focus area. By 1992, ABVKA had set up operations in eighteen of the sixty-four districts at the time in the eight north-eastern states.[58] In the south—specifically, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Kerala—its reach had expanded to sixteen of the twenty-eight districts where tribals formed a majority.[59]